pull back forces and create a zone of disengagement never saw the light of the day. The main reason for this was that the Pakistani side did not want to disclose its actual positions on the ground. But in case it had done so and the agreement had gone through, it would have left the Indian forces in a rather disadvantageous position with respect to the scenario discussed above. In this regard, I find that some strategists and journalists have failed to comprehend the operational nuances of war-fighting in the Siachen glacier, and also the political compulsions that would have an overarching bearing while looking at options for conflict termination. As rightly brought out by Lieutenant General V.R. Raghavan, '… Indians and Pakistanis have attributed motives and pressures to the political and military leaders of the two countries. What was the reality? Certainly, from the Indian side no Prime Minister can accept a solution which would be seen as unequal by the public and the Parliament.'[4]

Fundamentally, there really is no logic to support the alignment claimed by Pakistan, a dotted line direct from NJ 9842 to the Karakoram Pass as erroneously shown in some maps, covering a distance of approximately 80 kilometres as the crow flies. Neither is this alignment going northwards nor is there any glacier emanating from the Karakoram Pass, thus making a mockery of the agreement between the two countries, which unambiguously states that from NJ 9842 … 'thence north to the glaciers'. Therefore, India has been compelled to secure its territory and keep a permanent military presence on the Saltoro Range.

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[1] Harish Kapadia, *Into the Untravelled Himalaya*, Indus Publishing Company, New Delhi, p. 234.

[2] V.R. Raghavan, *Siachen – Conflict Without End*, Penguin Books India, New Delhi, p. 54.

[3] Description of the battle as seen from the Indian side.

[4] V.R. Raghavan, *Siachen – Conflict Without End*, Penguin Books India (P) Ltd, New Delhi, p. 145.